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TradesNKY and Campbell County Schools announce strategic partnership to expand regional career pathways

ALEXANDRIA, Ky. – TradesNKY and Campbell County Schools today announced a new strategic partnership to expand and strengthen hands-on career pathways for PK-12 students, including the development of a regional manufacturing pathway known as MAKE. This partnership model links classroom learning with real workforce opportunities, guiding students from early exposure in elementary school through exploration in middle school and hands-on experience, credentialing, and technical training in high school, ultimately preparing them for college and career success at graduation.

The announcement, made during a special event at Campbell County High School last night, builds on the district's nationally recognized career pathway model and introduces new resources, curriculum development and industry partnerships designed to prepare students for high-demand careers.

"We are incredibly proud and honored to partner with Campbell County Schools," said Phil Griffin, founder of TradesNKY. "They have already built an outstanding model for career pathways starting as early as preschool, and we're excited to work alongside them to expand these opportunities and help even more students discover meaningful, in-demand careers."

Campbell County Schools has already established itself as a leader in learning through its BUILD pathway, developed in partnership with TradesNKY. Building on that success, this next phase of collaboration will introduce the MAKE pathway, focused on manufacturing careers, and

further expand opportunities for students across all grade levels. This pathway development has been made possible through the generous support and expertise of our industry partners, especially Randy Hemmerle, Vice President of Administration at Krauss Maffei and TradesNKY Board Member.

“This is one of the most innovative and comprehensive pathway models in the state,” said Lorraine Moore, executive director of TradesNKY. “Campbell County has built something exceptional, and our role is to come alongside them, strengthen it and help scale what works. Together, we are creating more opportunities for students to explore high-demand careers right here in our region.”

The initiative will include:

- Development of the MAKE manufacturing pathway to complement existing career tracks
- Expansion of K-5 career clubs across all elementary school clusters
- Integration of TradesNKY resources into existing school programming
- Increased engagement with industry partners, who will work directly with students alongside educators
- Continued alignment of career pathways with academic achievement, reinforcing reading and math proficiency through real-world application

“We are proud to continue expanding our PK–12 Advanced Manufacturing and Automation Engineering pathway, creating meaningful opportunities for students to explore, develop, and apply skills aligned to high-demand careers,” said Dr. Shelli Wilson, Superintendent of Campbell County Schools. “Through this pathway, students will have access to hands-on learning, industry-recognized certifications, and experiences that prepare them for both college and the workforce. This public–private partnership with TradesNKY is essential in providing authentic experiences and connecting our students to real opportunities. We are truly grateful for their investment in our students and in the future of our community. This work ensures our students are prepared, confident, and ready to contribute to a rapidly evolving workforce.”

A key component of the program is direct involvement from industry professionals, who regularly engage in classrooms, providing real world insights and hands-on instruction in partnership with teachers. This approach ensures students are not only learning about career opportunities but actively experiencing them.

The expanded pathway model also connects early exposure at the elementary level with more advanced opportunities in middle and high school, creating a seamless system that helps students explore interests, build skills and pursue certifications, employment or continued education after graduation.

TradesNKY and Campbell County Schools will continue working with educators, business leaders and community partners to grow and sustain the program.

About TradesNKY

TradesNKY is a Kentucky-based nonprofit dedicated to expanding awareness of and access to careers in the skilled trades. Through partnerships with schools, industry and the community, TradesNKY helps students explore high-demand career pathways and prepares the next generation of skilled workers to strengthen Northern Kentucky's workforce.

For more information, visit www.tradesnky.org.

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